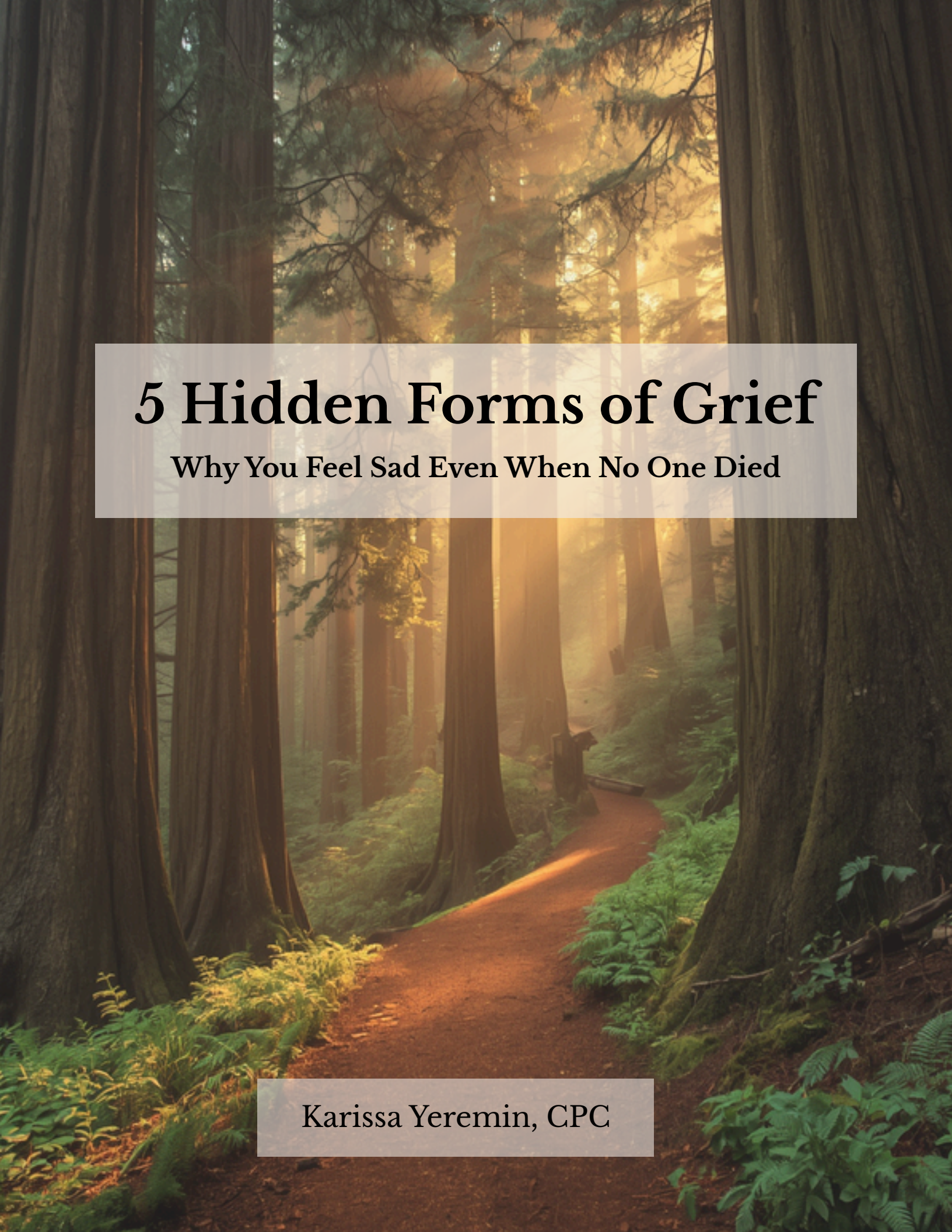


A misty forest path with sunlight filtering through the trees. The path is a narrow, reddish-brown trail that winds through a dense forest of tall, slender trees. Sunlight beams through the misty air, creating a warm, golden glow. The forest floor is covered in green ferns and moss. The overall atmosphere is serene and contemplative.

5 Hidden Forms of Grief

Why You Feel Sad Even When No One Died

Karissa Yerebin, CPC

Introduction

01

When most people think of grief, they think of death. But grief is much bigger than that.

Grief arises whenever we lose someone, something, or some version of life that mattered to us. It can appear after a divorce, a diagnosis, a career change, a child leaving home, or the realization that life didn't unfold the way we hoped.

Many people are carrying grief they don't even recognize as grief. If you've been feeling sad, lost, stuck, overwhelmed, or emotionally burdened, this guide is for you.

As you read, notice which forms of grief resonate with your own experience. You may discover that what you've been carrying has a name—and that naming it is the first step towards honoring it.



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Ambiguous Loss

02

What Is It?

Ambiguous loss occurs when a person, relationship, or dream is gone, but not completely gone. There is no clear ending or closure.

You are left living in the tension between presence and absence.

What Can it Feel Like?

- Confusing
- Unresolved
- Difficult to explain
- Like you're waiting for closure that never comes
- Feeling stuck between holding on and letting go

Common Examples

- Divorce while co-parenting
- Receiving a diagnosis (for yourself or a loved one)
- Estrangement from a family member
- A loved one living with dementia
- An adult child moving away
- Losing the future you thought you would have

Why People Often Miss It

There is no funeral, no ceremony, and often no clear ending. Because the loss remains partially present, people may not realize they are grieving.

Reflection Question

What in my life feels both present and absent at the same time?



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Disenfranchised Grief

03

What Is It?

Disenfranchised grief is grief that is not fully recognized, validated, or understood by others.

You may be grieving deeply while receiving little support because society doesn't see your loss as significant.

What Can It Feel Like?

- Invisible
- Isolating
- Lonely
- Like you have to justify your pain
- Like others expect you to "just move on"

Common Examples

- Divorce
- Friendship breakups
- Miscarriage
- Receiving a Diagnosis (for yourself or a loved one)
- Infertility
- Pet loss
- Losing a job or career identity
- The end of a meaningful life chapter

Why People Often Miss It

When others don't acknowledge a loss, we often stop acknowledging it ourselves.

Reflection Question

Is there a loss I've experienced that I don't feel fully permitted to grieve?



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Chronic Sorrow

04

What Is It?

Chronic sorrow is an ongoing form of grief that comes in waves over time because the source of the loss or challenge continues to be present.

Rather than moving through a loss and leaving it behind, you encounter it again and again as life unfolds.

What Can It Feel Like?

- Waves of sadness that come and go
- Feeling fine one day and grieving the next
- Emotional exhaustion
- Tenderness around recurring reminders
- Wondering why you're "still grieving"

Common Examples

- Parenting a child with special needs or a chronic illness
- Living with your own chronic illness
- Ongoing caregiving
- Repeated losses related to disability or health challenges
- Long-term life circumstances that continually reveal new losses

Why People Often Miss It

Many people believe grief should have an endpoint. When sorrow returns months or years later, they assume something is wrong. In reality, recurring grief is often a normal response to ongoing loss.

Reflection Question

What loss keeps showing up in new ways throughout my life?



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Identity Grief

05

What Is It?

Identity grief is the sorrow that arises when you lose a version of yourself.

Sometimes our grief isn't about another person. It's about who you used to be, who you hoped to become, or what life required you to leave behind.

What Can It Feel Like?

- Feeling lost or disconnected from yourself
- Longing for a previous season of life
- Uncertainty about your future
- Questioning who you are now
- Missing parts of yourself

Common Examples

- Divorce
- Retirement
- Empty nest
- Perimenopause and aging
- Career transitions
- Major illness or injury
- Significant spiritual or life changes

Why People Often Miss It

We tend to focus on external changes while overlooking the internal identities we've lost.

Reflection Question

What version of myself am I longing for right now?



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Anticipatory Grief

06

What Is It?

Anticipatory grief is grief that occurs before a loss has fully happened.

You are grieving what you know is coming or what you fear may come.

What Can It Feel Like

- Anxiety mixed with sadness
- Worry about the future
- Emotional heaviness
- Trying to prepare for something painful
- Feeling guilty for grieving before the loss occurs

Common Examples

- An aging parent
- A terminal diagnosis
- Watching someone's health decline
- A child preparing to leave home
- The end of a marriage
- Major life transitions on the horizon

Why People Often Miss It

People often believe they shouldn't grieve something that hasn't happened yet. But the heart frequently begins grieving before the loss arrives.

Reflection Question

What future change or loss am I already carrying emotionally?



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Grief Doesn't Fit Neatly Into Boxes

07

As you've read through these different forms of grief, you may have found yourself relating to more than one.

That's because grief is complex.

The categories in this guide are not meant to be boxes that define your experience. They are simply lenses that can help you better understand what you're carrying.

A single loss can create many different kinds of grief at once.

For example:

A divorce may involve:

- Ambiguous Loss because your former partner is still present in some ways
- Disenfranchised Grief because others may not fully understand your pain
- Identity Grief because you're grieving the person you were within the relationship
- Anticipatory Grief as you face an uncertain future

A diagnosis may involve:

- Ambiguous Loss as expectations and assumptions change
- Disenfranchised Grief because others may not recognize the loss
- Chronic Sorrow as new challenges and losses emerge over time

Grief is rarely simple.

It is layered, personal, and deeply human.

Whatever your grief looks like, it deserves compassion.



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Reflection

08

Take a moment and ask yourself:

- What losses am I carrying?
- What losses in my life have I never fully acknowledged?
- What would it look like to offer compassion to the grief I carry?

You do not need to rush your healing.
You do not need to justify your sorrow.
And you do not need to carry it alone.

Sometimes the most powerful step is simply recognizing that what you're experiencing is grief.

When grief is named, it becomes easier to honor. And when it is honored, healing can begin.

If this guide resonated with you, I'd love to connect.
At Sacred Grove Coaching, I support people navigating grief, life transitions,
chronic sorrow, and emotional resilience with compassion, curiosity, and
hope.

You deserve support for the losses that others may not see.

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About Me

09



I'm Karissa Yeremin, founder of Sacred Grove Coaching.

I support people navigating grief, chronic sorrow, life transitions, and the losses that often go unseen by others.

I believe that when we give ourselves permission to acknowledge what we've lost and honor what we're feeling, we create more space for self-compassion, clarity, and resilience.

If something in these pages resonated with you, know that you're not alone.
Whatever you're carrying deserves care, attention, and support.

I'd be honored to walk alongside you as you continue your journey.



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